in overemphasizing moral and ideological principles in international affairs. There are bound to be contradictions in the actual conduct of nations in dealing with each other.'[48]

Whereas others criticized Nehru for his 'idealistic presumptions' in a Hobbesian world based on realpolitik, Dixit critiques Nehru for his naive belief that since India 'had no expansionist or aggressive designs against any other country, India would not face any threats to its unity or territorial integrity'.[49] Nehru apparently held the view that since India had decided to keep away from power blocs, it would be protected from negative implications of the cold war equations.[50] Dixit points out that India's neighbours joined the cold war – Pakistan in alliance with the United States, and China's initial alliance with the Soviet Union – and brought war to India's neighbourhood. India's lofty principles were not enough to deter others from pursuing cynical realism. Even though India was a status quo power, her neighbours China and Pakistan were revanchist as was amply demonstrated in the wars of 1948, 1962 and 1965.

Dixit and other analysts believe that Nehru's policies were reasonably successful until the India–China war of 1962. India was recognized as a major Asian power and as a leading voice on anti-colonialism and against racial discrimination in the United Nations. India was involved in the post-crises negotiations in Korea and Indo-China and was a leading contributor to UN peacekeeping operations in the Middle East. Even though the United States and its allies were disenchanted and 'estranged'[51] with India, they still maintained close ties and provided economic and technological assistance to India. Nehru's desire to build ties with fellow Asian countries was reflected in the 1947 Asian Relations Conference, followed by the Bandung Conference of 1955 and eventually the Non-Aligned Movement of 1961. But the war with China in 1962 exposed the chink in India's armour. Non-alignment and absence of superpower support had ended up encouraging Chinese aggression against India.